

CASE ID: 196706710775

EPISODE NAME: China Sanctions Burma Following 1967 Anti-Chinese Riots

1967/06/28 - 1975/11/15

Sender: China (710)

Target: Myanmar (775)

Issue: Improve Human Rights (8)

Final Outcome: Negotiated Settlement following sanctions imposition (10)

Summary:

On 1967/06/28, China began threatening the government of Myanmar (then Burma) with diplomatic and economic sanctions in the wake of violent anti-Chinese protests in the country.¹ China recalled its ambassador in response to the riots on 1967/06/29, and trade between the two countries declined by 93% the following year.² Relations were normalized in 1975.³

Narrative:

On 1967/06/28, China's Vice Foreign Minister, Han Nianlong, gave a letter of protest to the Burmese foreign minister to China regarding anti-Chinese rioting in Burma.⁴ In it, China accused the Burmese government of encouraging anti-Chinese mobs, demanded that they take immediate measures to prevent the escalation of violence, assure the security of Chinese citizens and the embassy, return the Chinese national emblem taken from the embassy, and punish Burmese rioters who killed Chinese residents during the riots, or risk military retaliation.⁵ The Chinese also recalled their ambassador to Burma on 1967/06/29.⁶ Although China never formally issued economic sanctions, trade dropped by 93% (to just \$4,000) the following year.⁷

The sanctions were a result of deadly anti-Chinese riots that broke out on 1967/06/25.⁸ Chinese students had defied the Burmese government's ban on wearing Mao badges, imposed by government leaders concerned about the spread of the Cultural Revolution, leading to a brawl between badge-wearing students and their teachers on 1967/06/22.⁹ By 1967/06/25, reports of Burmese citizens attacking Chinese residents began to emerge.¹⁰ These escalated into full-scale riots on 1967/06/26. About 200 rioters stormed the Chinese embassy and tore down a Chinese

¹ Fan, Hongwei. "The 1967 Anti-Chinese Riots in Burma and Sino-Burmese Relations." *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, vol. 43, no. 2, 2012, pp. 234–56. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41490323>.

² Ibid.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ "Anti-Chinese riots rock Rangoon." *The Hindu*, June 28th, 1967.

<https://archive.is/5ZUqu#selection-1371.2-1371.33>.

⁹ Fan, Hongwei. "The 1967 Anti-Chinese Riots in Burma and Sino-Burmese Relations." *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, vol. 43, no. 2, 2012, pp. 234–56. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41490323>.

¹⁰ "Anti-Chinese riots rock Rangoon." *The Hindu*, June 28th, 1967

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emblem. Riots also occurred in other places across Rangoon, hospitalizing six Chinese citizens.¹¹ To quell the riots, Burma placed the Chinese Embassy under military control on 1967/06/28 and enforced martial law in the problematic areas on 1967/06/29.¹²

Following China's letter of protest to Burma, counter-protests against the anti-Chinese riots in front of the Burmese Embassy attracted over one million Chinese from 1967/06/29 to 1967/07/03. On 1967/06/29, Red Guards vandalized the Burmese Embassy, smashing its Burmese national emblem. That same day, Burma ignored China's formal demands. In 1967/08, Burma recalled its ambassador to Beijing,¹³ and by 1967/10/31, it ended its involvement in the Chinese economic assistance program.¹⁴

The crisis ultimately resulted in a collapse of relations between China and Burma. China began to support the Burmese Communist Party's rebellion against Burma's government.¹⁵ Relations were normalized on 1975/11/15,¹⁶ with the signing of a non-aggression pact between China and Burma.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Fan, Hongwei. "The 1967 Anti-Chinese Riots in Burma and Sino-Burmese Relations." *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, vol. 43, no. 2, 2012, pp. 234–56. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41490323>.

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ "Ten Years of Chinese Communist Foreign Policy." *United States Central Intelligence Agency*, April 9th, 1968. <https://www.cia.gov/readingroom/docs/polo-18.pdf>.

¹⁵ Fan, Hongwei. "The 1967 Anti-Chinese Riots in Burma and Sino-Burmese Relations." *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, vol. 43, no. 2, 2012, pp. 234–56. *JSTOR*, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41490323>.

¹⁶ Taylor, Robert. "General Ne Win: A Political Biography." *Asian Education and Development Studies*, vol. 5, no. 3, 2016, pp. 355–358. <https://doi.org/10.1108/AEDS-08-2015-0037>.